

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 2 OF 12

Daily Bread

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the one who opens the mail at the kitchen table and does the sums twice. You are not a failure. You are a person with a bill.



Father Lucas



BOOK 2

This book: Money, debt and provision: from shame, to order, to trust.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

Days 31–61 of 365 · The Year of Untied Knots

Knot of the month: Money (and, quietly, work, forgiveness and surrender).

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

Dear friend,

You finished the first book, and you're still here. That tells me something about you.

This month we go into the kitchen. We open the drawer, the envelope, the checkbook, the places where fear keeps its papers. I won't tell you money doesn't matter. It does. A house runs on bread and light. But you were never meant to carry the numbers alone, in the dark, at night.

Mary knew a short purse. She'll sit at your table. Each morning we take one small, honest step. One envelope. One call. One coin given away. Bring your coffee, and bring your doubts. The bills can wait one minute.

Thirty-one mornings. Let's begin.

Father Lucas

THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS

- **Week 1:** The truth of the numbers. Shame, the unopened envelope, what you really owe.
- **Week 2:** Order and phone calls. Asking for time, asking for help, asking family.
- **Week 3:** Trust and giving. Giving from little, and the bread you already have.
- **Week 4:** Contentment and the candle. Thanks, enough, and a flame for the daily bread.

THREE PROMISES FOR THIS MONTH

I. *I will open the page before I open the mail.*

II. *I will say the true number out loud, to Mary first.*

III. *I will take one small step a day, and no more.*

IV. --

Psalm of the month: Psalm 65, the year crowned with bounty.

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

The truth of the numbers

DAYS 31 TO 37

Shame, the unopened envelope, what you really owe.



DAY 31

The Kitchen Table at Night

You crown the year with your bounty. Your carts overflow with abundance.

PSALM 65:11 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Welcome to the second book. Last night the bills came out of the drawer again, and now they sit on the kitchen table, face down, like cards nobody wants to play.

I won't make this smaller than it is. Money fear is a lonely fear. It sits at the table long after the house has gone to bed. But that table has held your bread for years. It can hold this too, and Mary can pull up a chair.

Today we only sit down. No sums. No fixing. Just the table, the coffee, and her.

Mary, it's the kitchen table, and it's late. Here are the bills, face down, and here is the fear that sits beside them. I'm not asking you to make them disappear tonight. I'm asking you to sit with me while I look. Take the edge off the dread, and give me one calm breath. We'll start there. Amen.



TODAY

Sit at your kitchen table with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. Leave the bills where they are, face down. Just sit.

☐ DONE

What does the fear say to me when the house is quiet?

PSALM

65 — the year is crowned with bounty; start with the One who sets the table.



DAY 32

Shame Is Not a Bill

Have mercy on us, LORD, have mercy on us, for we have endured much contempt.

PSALM 123:3 (WEB)

Let's say the hard word first. Shame. It makes you cross the street. It makes you let the phone ring. But shame isn't a bill, my friend. Nobody mails it to you. You pay it every day anyway.

Years ago, Eileen quit shopping at Sal's corner store because she owed him. She walked eleven blocks to avoid his face. Sal found her after Mass. "Eileen," he said, "I miss you. The bread's the same."

Most people are Sal. Mary certainly is. She isn't counting what you owe. She's glad you walked in.

Lord Jesus, I've been hiding. From the mailbox, from the phone, from a neighbor's eyes. I'm tired of walking the long way around. Take this shame off my shoulders and put it where it belongs, in your hands. Let me look one person in the eye today without apologizing for being poor. Mary, stand beside me when I go out. Amen.



TODAY

Stand at your front door and say out loud, "I'm tired, and I'm still here." Then open the door and look at the street for a moment.

☐ DONE

Who am I avoiding because of what I owe them?

PSALM

123 — mercy for the ones who have had their fill of contempt (changed from 70).



DAY 33

Open the Envelope

When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you.

PSALM 56:3 (WEB)

The envelope has been on the shelf by the phone since before you can remember. It isn't getting lighter. Every day it waits, it grows a little in your mind, until it's the size of the house.

Here's a small truth from an old priest who has opened his share: the paper is never as big as the dread. It's just paper, with a number and a date. A number can be looked at. Dread can't.

Today you open one. Only one. You don't have to fix it this morning. Mary will stay with you.

Gentle Mother, my hand is shaking and it's only an envelope. Be with me when I tear it open. Whatever the page says, let me read it slowly, all the way to the bottom. Don't let me panic at the first number I see. Give me a steady breath, and a clear head to take the next small step. Amen.



TODAY

Open one envelope you've been avoiding. Read it all the way through, then set it on the table, flat, and rest your hand on it for one breath.

☐ DONE

What did I think it would say, and what does it say?

PSALM

70 — the shortest prayer for the longest week; say it with the envelope in your hand.



DAY 34

What You Actually Owe



So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.

PSALM 90:12 (WEB)

At night, what you owe is a monster with no edges. It's every bill at once, plus the ones you've forgotten, plus the ones that haven't come yet.

In daylight, it has edges. Nine bills, say, or five, or twelve. You can count that. You can write the names on a page, and a page has a bottom.

That's why the psalmist asks God to teach us to count. Not to panic. To count. Mary counted the same way in Nazareth: one loaf, one lamp, one jar. Small things have names.

Lord, teach me to count, and teach me not to drown. Let me write the names without flinching. Let me see the real size of it, and not the size my fear has painted. Give me a heart of wisdom for the next hour, and a quiet mind while I work. I will do the counting. You do the holding. Amen.



TODAY

Take one sheet of paper. List every bill by name, one line each, no amounts. Count the lines and say that number out loud.

☐ DONE

Which is bigger this morning, the real list or the one in my head?

PSALM

90 — teach us to count our days; the psalm for a person with a list (changed from 72).



DAY 35

Give Us This Day

Give us today our daily bread. Forgive us our debts, as we also forgive our debtors.

MATTHEW 6:11–12 (WEB)

The most famous prayer in the world has a line about money, and Jesus put it right in the middle of it: "Give us today our daily bread." Not this year's bread. Not the pension, the savings, the plan. Today's bread.

Look at what he leaves out. He doesn't teach us to ask for a full pantry. He teaches us to ask for the day. A day is a size a person can carry. Yesterday is gone, and tomorrow hasn't arrived with its mail.

Pray it the way you'd ask a neighbor for a cup of flour. Plainly.

Our Father, I won't ask for the whole year. I'll ask for today. Give me bread for these hours, and the sense to share what's left. Forgive me the debts I can't see, and the grudges I hold over debts others owe me. Let me eat this noon without fear sitting at the table. Today is enough. Amen.



TODAY

Say "Give us today our daily bread" out loud, slowly. Stop after the word "today" and stay quiet for ten seconds. Then finish the line.

☐ DONE

What would "enough for today" look like at my table?

PSALM

86 — "I am poor and needy"; the first line is a prayer a beggar and a king can both say.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Today's bread is only today's. Skip the morning, and tomorrow can't eat it for you. Come back to this page tomorrow, same hour, same chair. Three minutes is a small door for a whole day.



DAY 36

Count the Coins Like Mary



and to offer a sacrifice according to that which is said in the law of the Lord, "A pair of turtledoves, or two young pigeons."

LUKE 2:24 (WEB)

Here's a small fact people skip. When Mary carried her baby to the temple, the law asked for a lamb. But there was a kinder rule for the poor: two small birds would do. Luke tells us that's what she brought. Two birds.

So Mary has stood where you stand. She counted what was in the pouch and decided it would have to be enough. She isn't embarrassed by a short purse. She's the Mother who made do and made a home.

Today you count too. Not to be ashamed. To be honest, as she was.

Mary of Nazareth, you carried two small birds where others carried a lamb. Teach me to bring what I have without apology. Here are my coins, here is my pantry, here is my short month. Bless the little as you blessed your own. Let me stop measuring myself against other people's tables. Make it enough. Amen.



TODAY

Empty the loose coins from your pocket or purse into a saucer. Look at them a moment and say, "Mary, this is what I have."

☐ DONE

What do I have in my hands that I forgot to count?

PSALM

112 — the one who deals graciously stands firm; a short purse can still be steady.



DAY 37

The Debt You Fear Most



I lift up my eyes to you, you who sit in the heavens.

PSALM 123:1 (WEB)

Every house has one. Not always the biggest debt, but the one that wakes you. The medical bill, the loan from your brother, the card you swore you'd never use. You know the one I mean. It may not even be the largest. Fear doesn't measure.

Fear picks a favorite. And what we fear most, we look at least, so it grows in the dark.

Today we turn it toward the light. Not to pay it. Just to say its name to Mary, who isn't afraid of names. Say it plainly, and let her hear it first.

Holy Mother, there is one debt I can hardly look at. You know which. I give you its name, and I give you the fear that comes with it. I don't ask you to wipe it away this morning. I ask for the courage to face it, and for one honest person to help me carry it. Let it be smaller in my hands than in my head. Amen.



TODAY

Write the name of the debt that scares you most on a card, and tuck it under your rosary. Name only. No numbers.

☐ DONE

What would I do first if this debt weren't a secret?

PSALM

123 — eyes lifted like a servant's, watching the hand that feeds.



WEEK 2

Order and phone calls

DAYS 38 TO 44

Asking for time, asking for help, asking family.



DAY 38

Call Before They Call You

Happy is he who has the God of Jacob for his help, whose hope is in the LORD, his God,

PSALM 146:5 (WEB)

There's a quiet dignity in being the first to call. The lender expects silence. The office has a stack of silent folders. Then your voice comes on the line, steady and polite, and you're a person again, not a file.

You don't need the money. You need your name, your account number, and one plain sentence: "I'm having a hard month, and I'd like to talk about what's possible." Most people answering a phone have heard it before. Some have said it themselves.

Mary does the rest. She walks in with you.

Lord Jesus, my thumb is over the number and my heart is in my throat. Go ahead of me on this call. Put a patient voice on the other end. Let me say my own name without shrinking, and say my need without excuses. Whatever they answer, let me hear it clearly, and write it down. Stay on the line with me. Amen.



TODAY

Call one office you've been putting off. Say your name, then, "I'm having a hard month. What are my options?" Write down the answer.

☐ DONE

What's the worst they can really say, and could I survive hearing it?

PSALM

146 — help comes from the God who gives food to the hungry, not from the powerful.



DAY 39

The Widow's Jar of Oil

Elisha said to her, "What should I do for you? Tell me, what do you have in the house?" She said, "Your servant has nothing in the house, except a pot of oil."

2 KINGS 4:2 (WEB)

A widow came to the prophet with a creditor at her door. He asked her one question: "What do you have in the house?"

Nothing, she said. Only a little oil. He told her to borrow empty jars from every neighbor and start pouring. The oil kept coming until the last jar was full. She sold it, paid the debt, and lived on the rest.

Notice the order. She started with the nothing. Then she looked in the corner. Then she asked the neighbors. She didn't pretend, and she didn't despair. She took inventory, and then she borrowed jars.

Lord, I come to you like the widow, with a little oil in a small jar. You know what's in my house today. You know what isn't. Bless the little I have, and send me the neighbors with their empty jars. Teach me to ask, and teach me to pour. I'll trust you with the rest of the shelf. Amen.



TODAY

Open your pantry, your fridge, or the drawer by the stove. Look at what you have in the house. Name three things out loud and say thank you.

☐ DONE

What is already in my house that I've been calling nothing?

PSALM

69 — "the waters have come up to my neck"; the cry of the one who is drowning and is heard.



DAY 40

Enough for Today

Therefore don't be anxious for tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Each day's own evil is sufficient.

MATTHEW 6:34 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle, who has cleaned our church for twenty years, keeps a card taped inside her cupboard door. It says, "Enough for today." Her mother gave it to her. She tells me she reads it every morning, even on the good days, because the good days need it too.

I think the card works because it cuts the fear where it grows. Fear lives in next month. It lives in the next winter. Today has a loaf, a light, a roof. Today is allowed to be enough.

Sit with that, and let tomorrow stay where it is.

Father, you feed the sparrows, and nobody sends them a statement. Let me eat today's bread today. When my mind runs ahead to the winter, to the next bill, to the day I can't picture, call it back to this chair. Show me what is mine to do this morning, and let me leave the rest on your table. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Each time tomorrow walks in, whisper, "Enough for today."

☐ DONE

What am I carrying today that belongs to next month?

PSALM

37 — "a little that the righteous has"; the psalm for a small, steady table.

41

DAY 41

The Face You Avoid at the Market

They looked to him, and were radiant. Their faces shall never be covered with shame.

PSALM 34:5 (WEB)

There's a face you steer around in the grocery store. Maybe a cashier who saw your card declined once. Maybe a neighbor you owe a favor. You turn down the cereal aisle, you wait in the car, you let the clock run.

I understand. I once hid behind the canned goods from a woman I owed a phone call. A priest, hiding behind the beans.

The psalm says the ones who look to God are radiant, and their faces are never covered with shame. Not because they owe nothing. Because they stopped hiding it.

Mary, I know which aisle I avoid. I know whose eyes I dodge. Walk beside me the next time I go out, and lift my chin a little. Let me say good morning like a person with nothing to hide, because you already know everything, and you stay. Take the heat out of my face, just for today. Amen.



TODAY

Step outside and greet the first person you see with a plain hello. Look up as you say it, and let your face stay open.

☐ DONE

Whose eyes am I protecting myself from, and what do I fear they'll see?

PSALM

34 — a face turned toward God is not covered with shame (changed from 49).



DAY 42

A Dollar Given Is Not Lost



He who has pity on the poor lends to the LORD; he will reward him.

PROVERBS 19:17 (WEB)

The smallest gift is the hardest one to give when your own purse is thin. You do the math in your head, and the math says no.

Last winter Tom, my neighbor, who lives alone, pressed a can of soup into my hand at the door. I knew what his pantry looked like. I tried to refuse. He said, "Father, the soup is for you. The giving is for me." He walked back straighter than he came.

Giving from little tells your own heart a secret: you are not the bottom of the well.

Lord, I don't have much to give, and you know it. So take the little. Here is a coin, here is a can, here is an hour. Let it land in a hand that needs it today. Keep me from counting what I gave, and from boasting about it. Teach my hands that they're open, not empty. Amen.



TODAY

Give a dollar or a can of food to someone who needs it. No speech, no name. Then walk home a little lighter.

☐ DONE

Who has less than I do this morning, even by a little?

PSALM

65 — the carts overflow; what you give lands in a bigger hand.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Giving is a muscle, and so is keeping a hand closed. Skip a week, and the fingers forget how to open. Give something small again tomorrow. The knot only stays loose in a hand that keeps moving.



DAY 43

Your Old Pride

When pride comes, then comes shame, but with humility comes wisdom.

PROVERBS 11:2 (WEB)

Pride is a hard word to hear at your age, so let me say it kindly. You worked your whole life so you'd never have to ask anybody for anything. That wasn't a flaw. That was your backbone.

But a backbone can lock. It can keep you from the daughter who'd gladly help, the church pantry, the neighbor with a car. Humility, the Book says, is where wisdom comes in.

Not a doormat. A door. Today, put the old pride in a box for an hour. Not forever. You can have it back at lunch.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, this one is old and stiff. I learned it young: don't owe, don't ask, don't bend. It served me well, and now it's choking me. Loosen it a little. Let me bend without breaking. Let me say "I need help" to one person this week, and not feel the floor fall away. Amen.



TODAY

Pick a small object that stands for your pride: a pen, a wallet, an old watch. Put it in a box and close the lid for one hour.

☐ DONE

What would I let someone do for me if I weren't so stubbornly proud?

PSALM

72 — he hears the one with no helper; there is no shame in being that one.



DAY 44

The Letter From the Bank

In the day of my trouble I will call on you, for you will answer me.

PSALM 86:7 (WEB)

The envelope with the little window. You know it by the weight, thick or thin, and either way the stomach drops. A letter from the bank, the card company, the office that keeps track of what you owe.

These letters are written to frighten, a little. Their voice is cold and their words are long. But a letter is just a person's question on paper. Somebody at a desk wants an answer. They don't know your name, or that you hold your coffee with both hands.

Today we only gather them in one place. A scattered fear is bigger than a stacked one.

Lord, there's a stack of cold voices in my house, and I've been letting them speak in the dark. Today I'll put them in one place and look. Be my light on the page. Show me what is urgent and what is only loud. And when I'm afraid, remind me: in the day of my trouble I call on you, and you answer. Amen.



TODAY

Gather every letter that worries you into one pile, newest on top. Put the pile in a shoebox or folder, and write a name on the front.

☐ DONE

Which letter is only loud, and which one is truly urgent?

PSALM

86 — "you will answer me"; the promise under every cold letter.



WEEK 3

Trust and giving

DAYS 45 TO 51

Giving from little, and the bread you already have.



DAY 45

Ask for Help Without Shame

For if they fall, the one will lift up his fellow; but woe to him who is alone when he falls, and doesn't have another to lift him up.

ECCLESIASTES 4:10 (WEB)

You've been the helper all your life. The one who brought the casserole, drove the neighbor to the clinic, lent money and never asked for it back. Now the roles have switched, and it feels like falling.

Hear the old book: when one falls, the other lifts. Being lifted isn't you failing. It's the plan. The people who love you are waiting for a door to knock on.

And if there's no one? Write to Sister Camille. She reads every letter, and she answers. You're not as alone as the quiet makes you feel.

Father, I have been the strong one so long that I forgot how to be held. Soften my pride a little, and soften my fear more. Give me the right person to ask, and the right words to start. Let me say the plain truth, without a speech. And let me receive the answer the way I used to give it, with a full heart. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person you trust and say, "I could use some help with something. Do you have ten minutes?" Then tell them the truth.

☐ DONE

Who would be glad to be asked, and what is stopping me?

PSALM

112 — the one who is gracious will not be shaken by bad news; he is held.

46

DAY 46

Bread From an Unexpected Hand

The ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening; and he drank from the brook.

1 KINGS 17:6 (WEB)

The prophet Elijah was fed by ravens. Twice a day, at a brook, bread and meat in the morning and again at night. Ravens! He didn't get to choose the delivery.

Provision rarely comes in the hand you'd pick. A neighbor's tomatoes over the fence. A grandchild's twenty-minute call. A coupon in the mail you almost threw away. A casserole on the step with no note.

Sometimes we're so busy watching for the big door that we step over the bread on the porch. Today, notice who has been feeding you.

Lord, you fed a man by the hand of a bird, so you can feed me by whatever hand you choose. Open my eyes to the bread I've stepped over. Soften me, so I can receive it without apology. Bless the hands that have helped me this year, the ones I've thanked and the ones I haven't. Amen.



TODAY

Write the name of one person whose hand has helped you this year on a card. Say thank you to God for them, out loud.

☐ DONE

Whose small kindness did I treat as nothing this year?

PSALM

123 — eyes on the hand that feeds, whatever hand it turns out to be.



DAY 47

The Drawer You Avoid

who executes justice for the oppressed; who gives food to the hungry. The LORD frees the prisoners.

PSALM 146:7 (WEB)

Every kitchen has one. Rubber bands, dead batteries, takeout menus, a dried-up pen. And underneath, the things you don't want to see. A notice. A statement. A folded paper with your name on it.

We arrange whole mornings around a drawer we won't open. We reach for the one beside it. We learn which drawer sticks, and we let it stick.

The psalm says the Lord frees the prisoners. Some of us are held by something as small as a drawer. Today you open it. You don't have to read everything. Just let air in. For someone who's been holding her breath, that's a brave thing, and a kind one.

Lord who frees the captive, there is a drawer in my house that holds my fear. I've shut it for a long time. Open my hand to open it. Stand behind me while I look. Whatever is under the rubber bands, let me meet it with open eyes and a quiet heart. Free me from the dread of the drawer. Amen.



TODAY

Open the drawer you avoid. Take one paper out, look at it, and set it on the table. Close the drawer. That's all for today.

☐ DONE

What am I most afraid is in that drawer?

PSALM

146 — he frees the prisoners, and he lifts those bowed down.



DAY 48

One Coin in the Jar

He who is faithful in a very little is faithful also in much. He who is dishonest in a very little is also dishonest in much.

LUKE 16:10 (WEB)

Walt, our retired usher, keeps a coffee can by his front door. Every day he drops in one coin from his pocket. Not to get rich. He told me the sound it makes is the sound of a man who still puts something in.

When the can is full, he doesn't count it. He carries it to the box at the back of the church and starts over.

That's the whole lesson, my friend. Small things, done daily, tell your heart who you are. One coin says: I am not a person things only happen to. I am a person who does something, today.

Lord, I want to be faithful in the very little. Here is one coin, and I mean it. Let it be a prayer I can hear when it lands. Make my small steady ways into a quiet strength. Keep me from despising a day that looks small, because you built the world out of such days. Amen.



TODAY

Find an empty jar or coffee can. Drop in one coin from your pocket today, and set the jar where you'll see it each morning.

☐ DONE

What small thing could I do every day without fail?

PSALM

70 — a short prayer for a person who has little and says it anyway.



DAY 49

When Others Spend Easily

Rest in the LORD, and wait patiently for him. Don't fret because of him who prospers in his way, because of the man who makes wicked plots happen.

PSALM 37:7 (WEB)

You see it on the screen, in the aisle, on the porch next door: somebody's new car, new kitchen, new trip. It stings, and then you feel small for being stung.

Envy is a toothache. It tells you something is wrong, but not where. Often it isn't that you want their kitchen. It's that you're tired of counting while they aren't.

The psalm says, rest. Don't fret over the one who prospers. Their table is not your table, and their worries, whatever they are, are not yours either. Rest is the hard part. So let the resting be your prayer.

Lord, there's a splinter in my heart this morning, and it has someone else's name on it. I'm not proud of that. I don't want to want what they have. Pull it out gently. Show me what I already have and never noticed. Let me wish them well, and mean it, even if it takes me all day. Amen.



TODAY

Put your phone in another room. Look out a window for one full minute and name three things you can see that cost nothing.

☐ DONE

What do I envy, and what is it really telling me?

PSALM

37 — rest in the Lord and do not fret over the one who prospers (changed from 69).

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that stirs envy is still out there: the next catalog, the next visit, the next shiny thing on the next screen. Open tomorrow's page before the tide comes back in.



DAY 50

What Mary Owned

He has put down princes from their thrones, and has exalted the lowly. He has filled the hungry with good things. He has sent the rich away empty.

LUKE 1:52–53 (WEB)

Father Matthias, the old priest who gave me this book, once said, "Lucas, make a list of what Mary owned." I laughed. Then I tried. A shawl. A lamp. A few clay pots. A bench by the door. A son.

That was nearly all of it. And yet when she opened her mouth, she sang about the hungry being filled. A rich song from a poor house.

Maybe wealth is not the size of the cupboard. Maybe it's how much of it you can still say thank you for. You own more than she did, my friend. What would you sing?

Mother Mary, you sang when you had almost nothing, and your song is still the best I know. Teach me your kind of wealth: a lamp, a bench, a son, a yes. Let me look around my small house and see it filled. Turn my wanting into thanks, and my thanks into a song, even a quiet one. Amen.



TODAY

Write down three things you own that you'd carry out of the house first. Dear things, not valuable ones. Read the list out loud.

☐ DONE

What do I own that no bill could ever take?

PSALM

37 — "I have not seen the righteous forsaken"; an old person's testimony about little and enough.



DAY 51

The Bread You Already Have

Jesus took the loaves, and having given thanks, he distributed to the disciples, and the disciples to those who were sitting down, likewise also of the fish as much as they desired.

JOHN 6:11 (WEB)

Look at the bread. Really look. A slice of toast. A heel of rye. Somebody's hands grew the wheat, somebody's hands baked it, somebody's truck drove it here. You didn't make it, and it's on your plate.

When Jesus fed the crowd, He didn't start with abundance. He started with what a boy had in his basket. He took it, and He gave thanks. Then He passed it on. The thanks came first, before the food grew.

So today, thank first. Thanks isn't payment. It's the opening of the hand.

Jesus, you gave thanks over a few loaves before anyone was fed. I want to learn that order. Here is my toast, my soup, my small plate. Thank you for it, before I ask for more. Let me taste what I have. Let me stop eating standing up, in a rush, in fear. Sit with me at this table. Amen.



TODAY

Before you eat today, hold a slice of bread in both hands. Bless it out loud, then take the first bite slowly.

☐ DONE

When did I last taste my food and say thank you?

PSALM

49 — wealth cannot buy back a life; a plain table, blessed, already holds one.



WEEK 4

Contentment and the candle

DAYS 52 TO 61

Thanks, enough, and a flame for the daily bread.



DAY 52

Pray Before You Pay

You visit the earth, and water it. You greatly enrich it. The river of God is full of water. You provide them grain, for so you have ordained it.

PSALM 65:9 (WEB)

Patricia, who lives in Dayton with her husband Dale, prays over the checkbook. It isn't magic. She makes the Sign of the Cross, takes one breath, and then she pays. "I don't pay angry," she told me. "I pay awake."

Most of us pay in a flinch. Jaw tight, shoulders up, a small curse for the electric company. And a bill paid in a flinch costs more than the number on it.

Today, stop one second before the pen. One second is enough room for Mary to walk in. The same bill gets paid. But you're there when it happens.

Father, before I pay, I pray. Thank you for the light that came on this morning, the water that ran, the phone that rang. Bless the people on the other side of this payment, the ones I'll never meet. Let me pay without bitterness, and without that flinch in my shoulders. Keep my fingers loose today. Amen.



TODAY

Before you open or pay the next bill, close your eyes. Lay your hand flat on the envelope and make the Sign of the Cross over it slowly.

☐ DONE

Where in my body do I feel it when I pay a bill?

PSALM

65 — the river of God is full; grain comes because he ordained it, even for a small kitchen.



DAY 53

A Family Meeting About Money



Where there is no counsel, plans fail; but in a multitude of counselors they are established.

PROVERBS 15:22 (WEB)

Dale and Patricia kept their money worries from their grown children for years. Then one night their daughter saw a letter on the counter. She sat down and said, "Mom, Dad. How long?" They cried. And then they talked, the way a family talks, for the first time in a long time.

Secrets weigh more than numbers. Your children are not as fragile as you fear. Many of them are waiting for permission to help.

You don't need a plan today. You don't need the answers. You only need a time and a table.

Lord Jesus, you ate at a family table more than once, so you know how hard it is to say the true thing there. Soften my voice, and soften theirs. Let me speak without blame and listen without flinching. Give us one honest hour. Let love have the last word, not the numbers, and let us leave the table still family. Amen.



TODAY

Call one family member and ask for half an hour this week to talk about money, together. Set the day and the time, and write it down.

☐ DONE

Who in my family already suspects, and how would it feel to tell them?

PSALM

72 — a king who defends the needy; and a family that holds each other up.

54

DAY 54

No More Secrets in the Wallet

Teach me your way, the LORD. I will walk in your truth. Make my heart undivided to fear your name.

PSALM 86:11 (WEB)

A secret in the wallet is a stone in the shoe. You walk on it all day. A hidden card. A loan nobody knows about. A bill you pay from a drawer your spouse never opens. A hardship you don't mention because it would worry them.

I'm not here to scold you. I know the reasons were love. But love that hides something pays a price. It's tiring to guard a door all by yourself.

The psalmist asks for an undivided heart. One heart, the same inside and out. Today we only write the first line of it.

Lord, I have kept a door shut for love's sake, and now it's heavy. Teach me your way, and make my heart undivided. Show me which secret to set down first, and who should hear it. Let me trust that the people I love are stronger than I have feared. Go before me into that conversation. Amen.



TODAY

Write a two-line note to someone you love about one money thing you've kept quiet. Seal it in an envelope. Decide tomorrow whether to give it.

☐ DONE

What would feel lighter if one person knew?

PSALM

86 — an undivided heart; the walk in truth begins with one honest line.



DAY 55

Provision From Every Direction

My God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 4:19 (WEB)

Not all provision looks like money. Sometimes it's a woman handing you a jar of jam. A son-in-law who fixes the faucet and says nothing. A library card. A free lunch at the senior center. A neighbor with a snow shovel and a good back.

Paul says God will supply every need. He doesn't say every want, and he doesn't say how. The supply is bigger than our map, which is why we're so often surprised.

So draw a new map. Where has your bread really come from this year? Start with the jam.

Father, you supply in ways I don't plan for. Open my eyes to every hand that has helped me, the big ones and the small ones. Let me receive without shame and thank without rushing. When I'm tempted to say that nothing is coming, show me the jar of jam on the step. Let me trust the whole of your map. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud three places your bread has come from this year: a person, a place, a surprise. Say "thank you" after each one.

☐ DONE

Which of my needs was met in a way I never expected?

PSALM

112 — the one who gives freely is not afraid of bad news; his heart is steady.



DAY 56

Thank the Bills

In everything give thanks, for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus toward you.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:18 (WEB)

A strange order, I know. Today you thank the bills. Not because they're kind. Because each one is a receipt for something you've had. The electric bill is the light in the hall. The water bill is a hot bath and a washed cup. The phone bill is your daughter's voice at the end of a long day.

Look at each paper and see what it paid for before it asks what you owe. Thanks doesn't erase the number. It changes who is holding it, from a debtor in the corner to a guest at a table that is still, somehow, set.

Lord, thank you for the light I didn't earn, for the water that ran this morning, for the phone that rings. I've called these papers my enemies. Today I call them what they are: the cost of a warm house. Let me pay them with a lighter heart. And where I can't, let me ask with a steady voice. Amen.



TODAY

Pick up one bill. Say out loud what it paid for: "Thank you for the light." Then set it down gently, face up.

☐ DONE

What did the last bill I dreaded actually give me?

PSALM

123 — mercy first, thanks after; the psalm of a person who has had enough of contempt.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you opened this month stays open only while a hand is on it. Doors drift. Come back tomorrow, and every morning after. Thanks is the hand on the door.



DAY 57

The Gift You Can Still Give

For if the readiness is there, it is acceptable according to what you have, not according to what you don't have.

2 CORINTHIANS 8:12 (WEB)

Tom lives two doors down, alone. Years ago I began stopping at his window with no errand. Ten minutes. We talked about the weather and about the roses his wife planted. Nothing got fixed. Tom told me later that those ten minutes were the thing he waited for all week.

You may feel you have nothing to give. Paul says a gift is welcome according to what you have, not what you don't. You have time. You have a chair. You have two good ears. That is a gift nobody can send a bill for.

Lord, I thought I had nothing to give, and I was wrong. I have an hour. I have a chair. I have two good ears. Show me who is waiting for them. Take my time and turn it into someone's company. Make me a small loaf for a hungry afternoon, and keep me from rushing away. Amen.



TODAY

Give ten quiet minutes to someone lonely. Sit with them, in person or on the phone, and just listen. Don't fix anything.

☐ DONE

Who would be glad of ten minutes of my attention?

PSALM

146 — he upholds the widow and the fatherless; and he lets us help.

58

DAY 58

What You Won't Buy Today

Be free from the love of money, content with such things as you have, for he has said, "I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you."

HEBREWS 13:5 (WEB)

I'm not going to tell you to stop buying coffee. Nobody was ever rescued by a skipped coffee. But most of us have a small hunger that goes shopping. A tired afternoon, an ad that follows you around, a little something to feel better. It feeds you for ten minutes. Then the bag sits in the closet.

Today, find the one small thing you'd have bought out of tiredness, and let it wait. Not forever. One week. Often the wanting has moved on by then. And you will have shown yourself that you can say, not today.

Lord, I buy small things when I'm lonely, and it never works for long. Teach me to hear what the wanting is really asking for. Is it company, rest, a kind word? Give me that instead. Let me close the catalog and open my hands. You said you will never leave me. Let that fill the empty hour. Amen.



TODAY

On a scrap of paper, write down one small thing you'd have bought today. Put it in a drawer for one week.

☐ DONE

What was I really hungry for the last time I bought something small?

PSALM

70 — help me now, and teach me to wait; a short prayer for a restless wallet.



DAY 59

Trust Is a Daily Muscle

It is because of the LORD's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because his mercies don't fail. They are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness.

LAMENTATIONS 3:22–23 (WEB)

Nobody wakes up trusting. Some mornings you wake with the worry already in your mouth, like a bad taste. Trust isn't a feeling that arrives. It's closer to a muscle: sore at first, strong later.

You don't lift the heavy weight on day one. Eileen began with the four minutes it takes to boil an egg, not checking her balance. That was her whole trust, and it counted.

Today your weight is one minute with your hands open. Tomorrow, a morning. By and by a month, and you'll be surprised at the arm you've grown.

Lord, I'm not good at trusting. I've been burned, and I've been late, and I've been right to worry. But I'm here. Here are my open hands. Here is one minute. Give me today's mercy, fresh as bread out of the oven, and let it be enough to stand on. Make my trust grow, one sore morning at a time. Amen.



TODAY

Rest both hands palm-up on your lap for one full minute. Each time they want to close, open them again.

☐ DONE

Where did I trust a little more this week than last?

PSALM

69 — "answer me, for your loving kindness is good"; the plea of a person learning to trust.



DAY 60

The Bread Candle

I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his children begging for bread.

PSALM 37:25 (WEB)

Here's what an old man wrote in the psalms: he has been young, and now he's old, and he has never seen the righteous forsaken, or his children begging for bread. Read that slowly. He isn't promising you anything. He's telling you what his own eyes saw over a long life. Bread came. Not always the bread he ordered. But bread.

You've been young, and now you're old too. What have your eyes seen? You've gone through lean months before. Think back. Who showed up? What came to the table?

Today we light a small flame for that bread.

Lord, I light this small flame for the bread that has come, and for the bread that will. Thank you for the lean weeks I got through, though I don't know how. Thank you for the hands I couldn't see. Keep my table, keep my house, keep the people I love. I blow this flame out as a prayer. Let the smoke rise to you. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle at breakfast and set a slice of bread beside it. Eat the bread slowly, then blow out the flame and say "Amen."

☐ DONE

What lean time did I get through that I never thought I would?

PSALM

37 — an old person's testimony: bread came, not always the bread ordered.

61

DAY 61

Daily Bread, Kept

The young lions do lack, and suffer hunger, but those who seek the LORD shall not lack any good thing.

PSALM 34:10 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Thirty-one mornings. Look at what you've done. You sat at the table with the bills face down. You said the number out loud. You opened an envelope, made a call, gave a coin away. Some of it was hard, and you did it anyway.

Father Jakob, long ago in Augsburg, prayed these pages every morning of his life. If you asked him his secret, I think he'd say only this: he didn't stop. A knot loosened can be tied again. The one that stays loose is the one touched every day by a patient hand.

Tomorrow's page is waiting. So is she.

Mary, thank you for the table. Thank you for thirty-one mornings, and for staying while I looked at what scared me. Keep the envelope opened, the call made, the coin given. Keep my daily bread daily. When the old dread tries to sit down again, sit down first. Pull your chair next to mine. I'll keep opening the page. You keep the knot loose. Amen.



TODAY

Read three names from your Names Page aloud. Say one sentence of prayer for each: "Mary, keep them in daily bread."

☐ DONE

What small habit from this month do I want to keep?

PSALM

34 — those who seek the Lord shall not lack any good thing (changed from 49).

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let this slip once, years ago. I told myself I knew it by heart. Within weeks the old dread was back at the table, and it had brought company. Open tomorrow's page. That's all I'm asking.

CLOSING OF BOOK 2 · DAILY BREAD

LOOK BACK

☐ Which envelope did I open this month, and what was really inside it?

☐ Who did I call, or ask for help, that I was afraid to?

☐ What did I give away, even a little?

☐ Where did my bread come from that I hadn't noticed before?

A LETTER AT THE CLOSE OF THE MONTH

Dear friend,

Thirty-one mornings ago, the bills were face down on your table. Look at them now. Some are paid. Some are still waiting. But they're face up, and you're sitting beside them with someone else in the chair.

I haven't made your money troubles vanish. I wouldn't lie to you about that. What I hope we've done is smaller, and lasts longer. We took away some shame. We put the numbers in daylight. We asked, we gave, we thanked. That was you, not me, and I'm proud of you.

A knot undone can be tied again. The tide that tied it is still out there. So keep the habit. One page, one candle, one honest step.

— Father Lucas

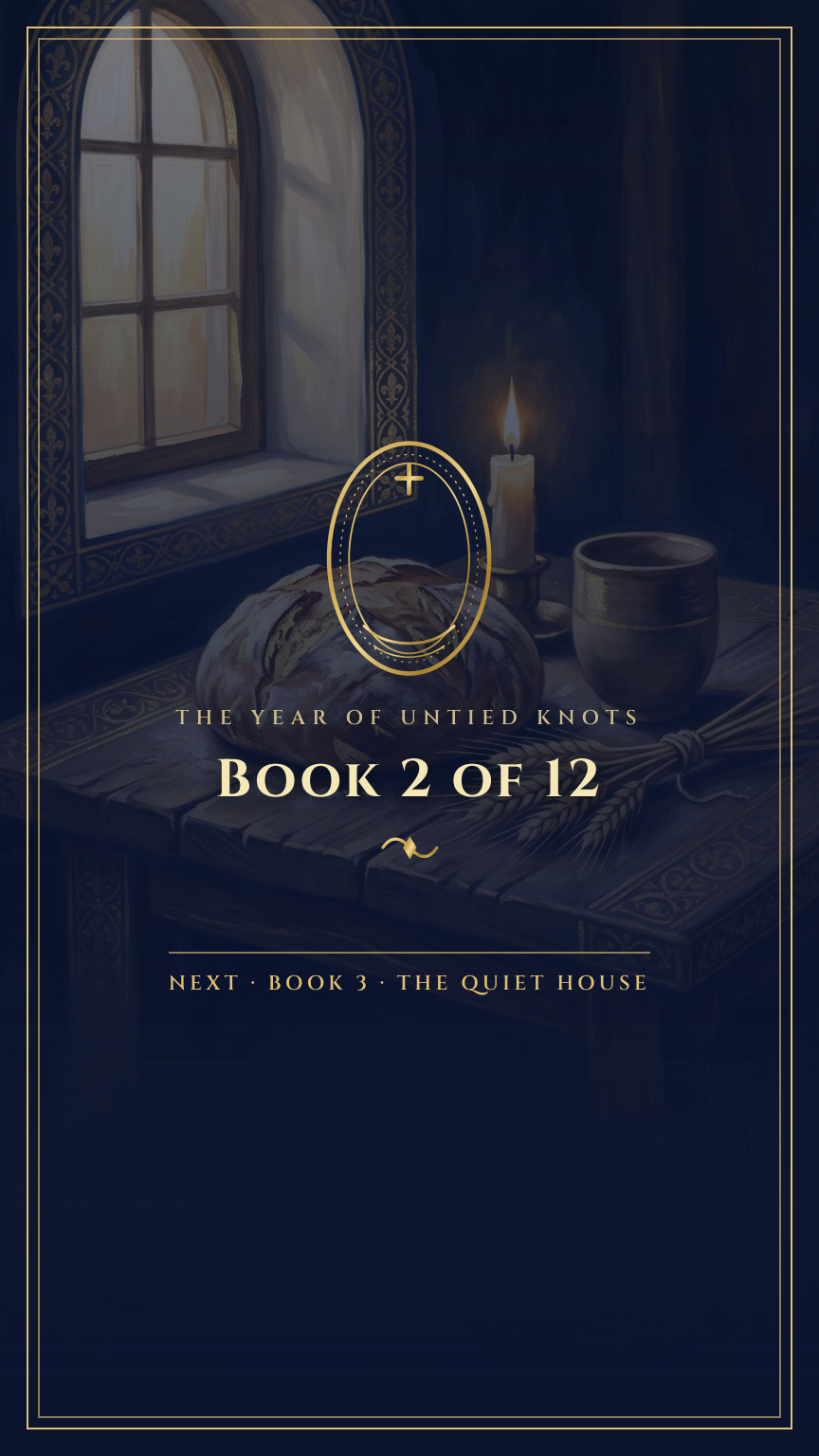
THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

BOOK 2 · DAILY BREAD · Date:

THE DAILY BREAD CANDLE

1. Light the candle at your kitchen table.
2. Say the names on your Names Page, slowly, one breath each.
3. Blow it out and say, "Amen."

Turn to Book 3 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 2 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 3 · THE QUIET HOUSE